

Chapter 188 - Part 2

Extra 10-2

Zhao Xuning turned her head and saw Zhao Ying dozing off with her chin propped up, sitting in front of the hospital bed.

Perhaps her movement startled Zhao Ying, who quickly woke up and made direct eye contact with her.

"You're awake." Zhao Ying stood up, pressing the call button by the bedside, then asked with concern: "How are you? Does your head still hurt?"

Zhao Xuning struggled to shake her head slowly, "How long did I sleep?"

"A day and a half." Zhao Ying said.

Zhao Xuning asked again: "Where's Shen Hui?"

Zhao Ying: "..."

"Is she alright?" Zhao Xuning asked again.

Zhao Ying shook her head: "She should be fine."

Shen Hui had also knelt for over a thousand steps with her. Zhao Xuning stared blankly at the door, saying nothing more.

She still hadn't fully emerged from the dream.

This state continued until evening.

During this time, Liang Shi came, Xu Qingzhu came, Zhao Ling came, and her parents came.

Everyone who saw her had serious expressions, all tight-lipped, as if her act of kneeling and kowtowing for three thousand steps hadn't happened.

Actually, Zhao Xuning could understand.

Everyone must be in shock.

If many years ago someone had told Zhao Xuning that one day she would kneel and kowtow up three thousand steps to win back a woman, Zhao Xuning would definitely have rolled her eyes, thinking they were sick.

But she never expected she would do it.

Even she herself couldn't think of it.

She couldn't even say why she had to do it.

In that instant, as long as Shen Hui asked, she would do it.

It had probably reached a kind of crazy degree.

That was the first time she realized—oh, so she loved Shen Hui to the point of madness.

Crazy.

Zhao Xuning cursed herself like this in her heart.

Zhao Xuning lay in the hospital room for an entire day, seemingly calm, but her heart was not calm.

She kept unconsciously looking outside the ward, again and again.

But never waiting for the person she wanted to wait for.

Until the second day, when Shen Hui appeared outside her hospital room.

When Zhao Xuning saw Shen Hui, neither of them spoke.

One standing, one sitting.

For a long time, so long that Zhao Xuning felt she was about to suffocate, unable to adjust her rhythm, Shen Hui finally spoke her first words: "Are you better?"

Just a simple greeting, but Zhao Xuning felt her throat go dry. When answering, she wanted to smile but couldn't manage it.

In the end, she gave up.

Zhao Xuning answered: "More or less."

Shen Hui sat by her bedside, not knowing what to say either.

All in all, the atmosphere was somewhat awkward.

Then Shen Hui took an apple from the side and handed it to her, "Can you still do it?"

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together and asked tentatively: "Do you want to eat?"

Shen Hui leaned back, casual and careless: "Want to watch."

Zhao Xuning picked up the fruit knife from the side. Her fingers were slender, and the back of her hand was mottled with bruises from too many IV drips, looking shocking.

She lowered her eyes and quietly began peeling the apple.

When Zhao Xuning first practiced her hand skills, to train her wrist strength and finger dexterity, she used apples for practice.

Back then, after they finished anatomy class, when Zhao Xuning had nothing to do, she would peel apples.

Shen Hui joked with her: "I'm about to become an apple spirit."

But that said, during that time Shen Hui's skin condition was particularly good.

But what Shen Hui liked most was watching her peel apple skins.

It was a blessing for those with obsessive-compulsive disorder.

She would maintain almost the same width, never breaking.

Mainly because Zhao Xuning looked particularly good when focusing on something.

Shen Hui especially loved looking at her profile.

Zhao Xuning quietly finished peeling an apple, then handed it to Shen Hui.

Shen Hui held it and took a bite—very crisp.

The ward fell silent again.

Zhao Xuning's fingers slid back and forth along the same line on the bedsheet.

Shen Hui slowly ate a few bites, then asked without warning: "Why won't you let me get engaged?"

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together, not answering.

"Is it because you still love me, or possessiveness?" Shen Hui asked again.

Zhao Xuning still didn't speak, not knowing how to answer.

She didn't want Shen Hui to know about those things.

That person had abandoned his pregnant girlfriend to be with her. That person was cold and cruel.

Handing Shen Hui over to such a person, Zhao Xuning couldn't feel at ease.

"Zhao Xuning." Shen Hui stared straight at her, her voice turning cold: "Speak."

With a hint of coercion.

Zhao Xuning didn't dare look at her.

"So you still want things to be like before?" Shen Hui asked.

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "No."

Shen Hui: "Then what do you want?"

Only then did Zhao Xuning look at Shen Hui.

After a long moment of eye contact, Zhao Xuning opened her mouth with difficulty: "I want to be with you."

Zhao Xuning paused, tears suddenly welling up in her eyes, feeling a pain in her heart.

She said: "Even if you torture me, I'm willing."

Zhao Xuning closed her eyes, a tear falling.

"Shen Hui." Zhao Xuning said: "Let me keep you."

That year, Shen Hui had said, "Zhao Xuning, if one day I want to break up with you, you just say 'let me keep you,' and then I'll know—you can't bear to part with me, I'm the one you love most in the whole world, you can't live without me. That way, I'll stay by your side. Understand?"

When Shen Hui said this, she was smiling, sitting with Zhao Xuning at the highest point of a drop tower¹, holding her hand tightly.

Then she shouted into the wind: "In the whole world, I love Zhao Xuning the most."

But Zhao Xuning had never said those words.

Zhao Xuning sat on the hospital bed, feeling her throat so dry she could barely speak. Every word felt difficult, her heart aching and afraid.

Afraid Shen Hui would refuse, afraid Shen Hui would scold her, even more afraid Shen Hui would leave without looking back, negating everything from the past.

But after a long while, Shen Hui looked up at her and smiled: "Alright."

When she smiled and said those two words, Shen Hui thought: What a fool.

Jumping into Zhao Xuning's world again and again.

Yes.

A crazy person and a fool.

They matched quite well.

Footnotes:

¹ Drop tower (跳楼机) - An amusement park ride that lifts riders to a height and then drops them in free fall